

“Cosmetic gynecology” means surgery or other treatment you choose to change how the genital area looks or feels. It also includes laser and heat treatments sold as “vaginal rejuvenation.” This sheet gives you honest facts. It covers what is proven, what is mostly marketing, and how to stay safe.

What's Included

- **Labiaplasty:** surgery to make the inner lips of the vulva (labia) smaller. People ask for it because of rubbing, pain with exercise or sex, or how it looks.
- **Other surgery** to change the look of the vulva, such as the skin over the clitoris or the outer lips.
- **Laser and heat devices** sold for a loose vagina, dryness or leaking urine.

A Word of Caution

Major medical groups say that these procedures are not medically needed when there is no health problem. They also say that safety and results are not well proven.

Laser and heat devices are not FDA-cleared for “vaginal rejuvenation,” dryness or leaking urine. The FDA has warned that they can cause **burns, scarring, and pain**, including pain with sex. In a careful study, a laser did no better than a fake treatment.

Proven treatments exist for dryness, leaking and prolapse. These include vaginal estrogen, pelvic floor therapy, pessaries and bladder surgery.

Learn the Terms

Elective

Something you choose. It is not medically needed.

Labia

The folds of skin, or lips, around the opening of the vagina.

Labiaplasty

Surgery to reshape or reduce the inner labia.

“Vaginal rejuvenation”

A sales term for laser or heat treatments. It is not a medical diagnosis.

FDA-cleared

Allowed by the FDA to be sold for a certain use.

Body dysmorphic disorder

A health condition where a person worries a great deal about a flaw in their looks that others do not see.

Is something “wrong” with me? Almost always, no. Vulvas look very different from person to person, and all of these are normal. A normal body does not need “fixing.” Surgery is a personal choice. It is never something you must do to be normal or healthy.

First 2–3 days

Swelling and soreness.
Use ice packs.

About 1 week

Wound check visit. Keep
the area clean.

Weeks 4–6

No sex, tampons or hard
exercise until cleared.

3–6 months

Swelling is gone and you
see the final result.

If You Are Thinking About It

- 1 Be clear on your goal:** comfort, function or looks. Ask if a proven medical treatment would work better.
- 2 Expect a talk about your feelings** toward your body. This is a routine part of a good visit.
- 3 Choose a trained surgeon** who does this often. Ask what results to expect.
- 4 Know the risks:** bleeding, infection, scarring, changes in feeling, pain with sex, or not liking the result. The wound edges come apart in about 3 to 8 in 100 people.

Call the office that did your procedure if you have:

- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, or chills
- Spreading redness, bad-smelling discharge, or the wound opening
- A burn or blister after a laser or heat treatment

Go to an emergency department if:

- You have heavy bleeding, such as soaking a pad an hour
- You cannot urinate for several hours and your bladder feels full
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Wound Care

- Sit in a few inches of warm water (a sitz bath) and use ointment as your team directs.
- Wear loose clothing.

Good to Know

- Take your time. A second opinion with no pressure is a good idea.

Three Things to Remember

- 1.** These are choices, not medical needs. A normal body needs no fixing.
- 2.** Laser “rejuvenation” is not FDA-cleared and carries FDA warnings.
- 3.** For dryness, leaking or prolapse, proven treatments work better.